

VEER

Claude for Absolute Beginners

The account, the screen, and the handful of habits that make it work.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Get set up and know exactly what you're looking at, with nothing left unexplained.

Have a real conversation instead of typing at it like a search box.

Fix an answer that's close but not right, without starting over.

Give it what it can't guess — the one habit that changes everything.

Know when it's likely to be wrong, and what to do about that.

Try one small thing a day for a week, so this doesn't stall after an afternoon.

You don't need to be good with computers. You don't need to know anything about AI.

Ten lessons. Read them in order the first time.

01

You are not late to this

You've been hearing about this for a couple of years. Colleagues mention it. Your niece uses it for something. There's a headline every week. Somewhere along the way it started to feel like a train you'd missed.

You haven't missed anything.

Here's the part nobody says plainly: **the genuinely useful bit is small**. It isn't a field of study. There's no certification, no vocabulary to memorize, no software to learn. The people getting real value out of this are not doing something clever. They're doing something simple, repeatedly.

What that looks like in practice, from people with ordinary lives:

Rewriting an email they'd been dreading for three days.

Turning a confusing letter from an insurer into four sentences of plain English.

Working out what to cook from what's in the fridge.

Talking through a decision with something that asks questions instead of offering opinions.

None of that is impressive. All of it saves a real half-hour.

WHAT ACTUALLY HOLDS PEOPLE BACK

It isn't skill. It's the belief that there's a right way to do this and they'll get it wrong. There isn't, and you can't.

Try this now. Think of one thing from the past week that took longer than it should have. Hold onto it — you'll hand it over in Lesson 5.

02

It's a conversation, not a search box

Most people's first attempt fails for the same reason, and it isn't their fault. Twenty-five years of search engines taught all of us to type the fewest possible words. Three or four keywords, press enter, scan the results.

So people open Claude and type something like *email to landlord*. Back comes something bland that sounds like a template. And the reasonable conclusion is: this isn't as good as everyone says.

The answer was generic because the request was.

A search engine looks for a page that already exists. Claude writes something new, for you, right now — and it can only work with what you've told it. Three words give it almost nothing, so it fills the gaps with the blandest possible average.

The whole shift is this: stop typing at it, and start explaining to it. Talk to it the way you'd talk to a capable person who has never met you and knows nothing about your situation.

That isn't a technique. It's the entire skill.

The same request, twice

THE SEARCH-BOX WAY

email to landlord about broken heater

That produces a formal, hollow letter that could be from anyone, to anyone, about any heater. You'd rewrite most of it.

THE CONVERSATION WAY

My heater has been broken for five days. I've messaged my landlord twice and had no reply. I don't want to be aggressive because I like living here and I'd like to renew the lease, but I've got a toddler in the house and it's genuinely cold now. Help me write something polite that makes it clear this can't keep waiting.

That produces something you could nearly send as-is.

Look at what the second one added: how long it's been, what's already been tried, what you're worried about, and what outcome you want.

None of that is technical. It's what you'd tell a friend in the kitchen.

THE TEST

If a stranger read only your request, would they know enough to help you? If not, that's what's missing — not a better phrasing.

Try this now. Take any request you'd normally type in four words. Say it out loud as if explaining to someone across a table. Type that instead.

03

Getting in

The whole setup takes about five minutes and there's nothing to install.

Open a browser and go to claude.ai. Type it into the address bar at the top of your browser, not into a search engine.

Make an account. An email address works. So does signing in with a Google or Apple account you already have, which saves you inventing another password.

Start on the free version. It exists, it's real, and it's enough for everything in this guide.

Don't pay for anything yet. You can't know what you need until you've used it for a week. Lesson 10 and the current-versions page cover when upgrading actually makes sense.

That's it. No setup wizard, no preferences to configure, nothing to download.

PHONE, COMPUTER, OR BOTH

There's a Claude app for phones and for computers, and it's the same account either way. Start a conversation on your laptop, pick it up on your phone at the bus stop. Nothing to transfer. If you're unsure, start in a browser — you can add the app later.

Try this now. Make the account. Don't type anything into it yet.

04

What you're looking at

Open it up and the first thing you'll notice is how empty it is.

This throws people. Most software greets you with menus, toolbars, a dashboard, a tour. This gives you a mostly blank screen. It feels like something hasn't loaded, or you've skipped a step.

Nothing is missing. The emptiness is the design.

The box. Near the bottom of the screen there's a wide empty box with a cursor blinking in it. That's where everything happens. You type there, press enter, and the answer appears above it. It reads like a text-message thread.

The list down the side. Every conversation is saved automatically, and they stack up in a list along the edge of the screen. Click any one to reopen it exactly where you left it. You don't have to save anything, and nothing gets thrown away.

Starting fresh. There's a "new chat" option, usually near the top of that list. Lesson 8 covers when you'd want one.

IF THE SCREEN LOOKS DIFFERENT FROM THIS

It will, eventually. Buttons move and get renamed. But the shape stays the same: a box to type in, a list of past conversations, a way to start a new one. Look for what a thing does rather than what it's called, and a redesign won't throw you.

Try this now. Open it and find those three things. Point at each one.

05

Your first real conversation

Now the thing itself. Type this, or copy it word for word:

TYPE THIS IN

I want to get a feel for what you can actually help me with. Ask me three questions about my life and what I spend my time on, then suggest one specific thing I could hand over to you this week.

Press enter.

Notice what happens: **it asks you questions instead of answering.** It does that because you told it to. Most people never do, which is why most first experiences are a wall of generic text.

Answer its questions the way you'd answer a friend. Short is fine. Rambling is fine. Half a sentence is fine. You are not being graded, and there is no format.

When it comes back with a suggestion, one of two things will be true.

It suggested something genuinely useful. Do that thing next, right there in the same conversation. Say *yes, let's do that one* and keep going.

It suggested something that misses. Also useful, and more common than you'd think. Say so: *That's not really a problem for me. What I actually spend too long on is...* It'll adjust immediately.

Correcting it is not a failure state. It's how this is supposed to go.

Either way you've now done the thing most people never get to: a **back-and-forth rather than a single request**. That's the difference between a party trick and a tool.

Remember the task from Lesson 1 — the one that took longer than it should have? Bring it up now, in this same conversation.

THEN TRY THIS

Something else that took me far too long this week was — can you help me with that?

Try this now. Do both halves: the opening question, then your own real task.

06

Tell it what it can't guess

This is the most valuable lesson in the guide. If you take one habit away, take this one.

Claude knows nothing about you. Not your job, not your family, not your town, not how you talk, not what happened last week. It isn't being cagey and it isn't holding back — it genuinely has no idea, every time you start.

So what you get back depends almost entirely on **what you tell it first**.

The good news: you don't need to write a briefing document.
Four things cover nearly everything.

Who it's for. The neighbour, your boss, your sister-in-law, a stranger at a company.

What's going on. The situation, in a sentence or two.

What you want to happen. The outcome you're after.

Anything that would change the answer. Money, timing, history, a sore spot.

You already know all four. The only new habit is saying them out loud before you ask.

What context actually does

WITHOUT CONTEXT

Write a birthday message for my father-in-law.

Warm, correct, and completely interchangeable. It could be for anyone's father-in-law.

WITH CONTEXT

Write a birthday message for my father-in-law. We get on fine but we're not close, and he's not a sentimental man — anything gushing would embarrass us both. He's turning 70, he has recently retired from thirty years of teaching, and he's obsessed with his allotment. Keep it short and a bit dry.

Now it has the relationship, the tone to avoid, the milestone, and something specific to him.

What comes back from the second one sounds like it was written by someone who knows him. Same tool, same thirty seconds of typing, completely different result.

WRITE IT ONCE, USE IT FOREVER

Most people's context repeats. Keep a few sentences about yourself — what you do, who you deal with, how you like to sound — in a note on your phone. Paste it in whenever it's relevant. Everything improves immediately, and later on there's a way to set it permanently.

Try this now. Rewrite the birthday example about someone real in your life.

07

The answer's close — now fix it

Here's where most people waste the most time. They get an answer that's nearly right, decide the whole approach failed, and start again from scratch with a longer request.

Don't. The conversation is still open. Steer it.

The first answer is a draft, not a verdict. Two or three small nudges get you further than one perfect opening request ever will — and each nudge takes about four seconds.

THE PHRASES THAT DO THE MOST WORK

Shorter — about half that. · Longer, and give me a specific example. · More casual, like I'm texting a friend. · More formal. · That's too salesy, make it sound like helpful advice. · Give me three versions so I can pick. · Keep the second paragraph and redo the rest. · Now turn that into an email. · Say that like I've never done this before.

Think of it like working with a photographer. You don't fire them after the first shot. You say *great — now step left, and try it brighter.*

What steering looks like

You: *Help me write a note to my neighbour about their tree overhanging my garden.*

It: a polite, slightly stiff, four-paragraph letter.

You: *Too formal. We're friendly, we chat over the fence. Make it sound like that.*

It: warmer, shorter, more natural.

You: *Good. Cut the last line, it's a bit passive-aggressive.*

It: the version you actually send.

Three exchanges, maybe forty seconds. You'd have spent longer staring at a blank page.

Try this now. Take anything it's given you and nudge it three times.

08

Why it forgets, and what to do about it

At some point a long conversation will start to drift. It'll lose the thread, forget something from the beginning, or repeat itself. People find this unsettling — it feels like something's broken.

Nothing's broken. There's a limit to how much of one conversation it can hold in mind at once. In a short exchange you'll never come near it. In a very long one, the earliest parts start slipping out of view.

What to do about it is simple: start a new conversation.

Use a new one when you switch to an unrelated task, when the current one has gone on a long time, or when it's clearly lost the plot. Carry on in the existing one when you're still working on the same thing and want it to remember what you've agreed.

NOTHING IS LOST WHEN YOU START FRESH

Old conversations stay in the list down the side, and you can reopen any of them. Starting a new one opens a clean page — it doesn't tear out the old ones.

A useful habit: when a long conversation produces something good, copy it somewhere of your own. Not because it'll vanish, but because things you have to go hunting for tend not to get used.

09

Sometimes it's wrong, and it won't sound wrong

This is the lesson that matters most, and the one most beginner guides skip.

Claude can be confidently, completely wrong.

Not garbled or obviously broken — wrong in the same calm, fluent voice it uses when it's right. A made-up statistic reads exactly like a real one. An invented detail about a law, a product, or a person arrives with the same steady confidence as a fact.

There's no tone of voice to listen for. That's the whole problem.

Why it happens, in plain terms: it produces language that fits, rather than looking up an answer. Most of the time what fits is also true, because it has read an enormous amount. But when it doesn't know, it doesn't go quiet — it produces something that *sounds* like the right kind of answer.

That's the failure mode, and it will never announce itself.

You don't need to check everything. You need to know which things to check.

The three-question check

Could I check this in one search? Names, dates, numbers, prices, rules, addresses. If it's checkable, check it.

Does it matter if it's wrong? A dinner suggestion, no. Anything you're about to send, sign, pay, or act on, yes.

Would I want a person to confirm this? If the honest answer is yes, that's your answer.

A useful move: ask it directly. *How confident are you about that?*
Is any of it worth checking? It will often flag its own shakiest claims.

THE FOUR YOU ALWAYS CONFIRM WITH A PERSON

Money. Legal matters. Health. And anything you can't undo.

Claude is genuinely good at helping you *understand* these things and work out what to ask — a letter from a solicitor, a diagnosis you didn't follow, a bill that doesn't add up. Use it for that. Then take the decision itself to someone qualified.

Try this now. Ask it something you already know the answer to, in an area you know well. See how it does. That calibrates you better than any amount of reassurance.

10

Where this fits in your week

The last thing to sort out isn't a skill, it's a habit. Plenty of people finish a guide like this, agree it was interesting, and never open the thing again.

You don't need a system. You need three moments where reaching for it is the obvious move.

When you're avoiding writing something. The complaint, the apology, the awkward reply, the thing that's been in your drafts for three days. This is the highest-value use for most people and the one most likely to stick.

When something confusing lands. A letter, a form, a bill, a contract, instructions that assume knowledge you don't have. *Tell me what this actually says and whether I need to do anything.*

When you're stuck deciding. Not to be told what to do — to be asked useful questions. *Ask me five questions that would help me think this through, then wait for my answers.*

A QUIET WARNING ABOUT THE FOURTH MOMENT

There's a temptation to use it for everything, including things you're already good at and enjoy. That's how people end up feeling worse about a tool meant to help. Hand over the parts you dread. Keep the parts you like.

The First Week

One small thing a day, ten minutes each. Tear this page out and leave it by the computer.

Day 1 — Say hello properly. The Lesson 5 conversation: ask it to ask *you* three questions first.

Day 2 — Hand over one real task. The thing you've been avoiding writing. Edit what comes back rather than accepting it.

Day 3 — Make something confusing plain. Paste in a letter, a bill, or a form. Ask what it says and what you need to do.

Day 4 — Get it to push back. Describe a decision and ask it to ask you questions rather than give an opinion.

Day 5 — Fix instead of restart. Take any answer and nudge it three times.

Day 6 — Test it where you're the expert. Ask about something you know well. Notice what it gets right and what it doesn't.

Day 7 — Do Day 2 again. Same kind of task, new instance. This is the day it stops being a novelty.

When it goes wrong

"It gave me a wall of text." It defaults to thorough. Tell it the shape you want: *Three sentences. A short list. Under a hundred words.* It complies immediately and remembers for the rest of that conversation.

"It completely misunderstood me." Almost always missing context rather than a bad question. Add who it's for and what you're trying to achieve, then ask again in the same conversation.

"It sounds like a robot." Show it your voice instead of describing it. Paste in something you wrote that you liked and say *match this tone.*

"It made something up." See Lesson 9. Ask what it's unsure about, and check anything checkable.

"I lost my conversation." You almost certainly didn't. Everything is saved in the list along the side of the screen.

"It said I've reached a limit." The free version gives you a generous but finite amount in a stretch of time. Wait and it resets. If you hit it regularly, that's the first honest signal you might want a paid plan — not before.

"It keeps apologising and going in circles." The conversation has drifted. Start a new one with a clean, complete description of what you want.

"I asked for something and it declined." Reword it and say what you actually need it for. If it still won't, that's a boundary rather than a bug — move on rather than trying to talk it round.

THE GENERAL RULE

Nearly every problem above is solved by one of three things: more context, a clearer description of the shape you want, or a fresh conversation. Try those in that order before concluding something is broken.

Current as of Q3 2026

The only page tied to things that change. Check you have the current edition.

Where to sign up. claude.ai in any browser, or the Claude app for phones and computers. Same account across all of them.

The plans. A free tier that's genuinely usable, and paid tiers above it — currently a standard **Pro** tier and a higher-usage **Max** tier. You're buying more usage and access to more capable models. Start free; upgrade when you actually hit limits.

The models. You'll see names like **Opus**, **Sonnet** and **Haiku**. The same assistant at different sizes: Haiku fastest, Opus most capable, Sonnet between. The current generation is the **Claude 5** family, alongside Haiku 4.5.

You mostly don't need to think about this — the app picks a sensible default. When you can choose, use the most capable one for anything that matters.

VERIFY BEFORE YOU RELY ON IT

Plan names, prices and model names change regularly. Check current details at the official source, not a printed page.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit from this guide and leave the rest.

Before you ask for anything, spend one sentence saying who you are and what you're trying to do.

That's Lesson 6, and it's worth more than the other nine combined. Not because the others are wrong, but because it's the one that turns a generic answer into a useful one — and almost nobody does it.

If you never learn to nudge an answer, never start a second conversation, never think about which model you're using, but you do say who you are and what you want first, you will get more out of this than most people.

Do this next

Worried about privacy, or about being misled? → Is This Safe?

— what it can and can't see, why it's sometimes wrong, how to check it, and the short list of things you should never type in. If you read one more guide, read that one.

Want ideas rather than instruction? → 101 Everyday Things to Ask Claude — ten chapters, every one a complete sentence you can type as-is.

Want better answers first time? → Asking Better Questions — Lessons 6 and 7 worked all the way through, with twelve before-and-after pairs.

Haven't got the free starter? → Your First Ten Minutes With Claude — six pages, free.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

DISCLAIMER

This is an independent educational guide created by Veer. It is not affiliated with, authorized by, sponsored by, or endorsed by Anthropic PBC. "Claude" and "Anthropic" are trademarks of Anthropic PBC, used here for identification and descriptive purposes only. All product features, model names, pricing, and interfaces described are those of Anthropic and are subject to change; verify current details at the official source. This guide reflects the author's own methods and opinions.

Nothing in this guide is legal, medical, or financial advice.

© 2026 Veer. Personal-use license — for your own use; please don't redistribute or resell.